

Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-
universality

Divine
control

Justice

Proportion- ality

Continuity

There is a different way of denying Dichotomy which deserves mention.

This is the idea that heaven and hell are much less uniform than one might think. Perhaps (as Dante wrote) there are different “circles” of hell, which differ significantly in their badness.

If there were enough such circles — and corresponding “levels” of heaven
— this might avoid violating Proportionality.

A residual problem is that on pictures like Dante's, there is still an enormous gap between the "worst" part of heaven and the "best" part of hell. Giving this up would seem to mean giving up on an important part of the traditional view of the afterlife.



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox



evil & lives
not worth
living

the existence of a perfectly good God.

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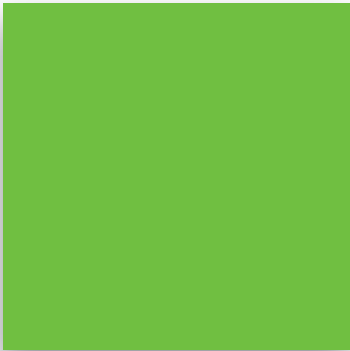
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Badness

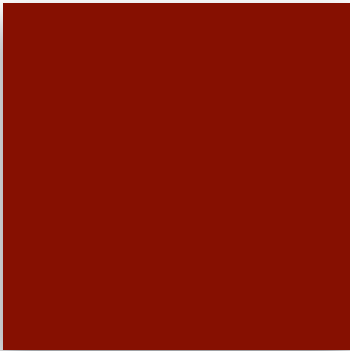
Dichotomy



Divine
control

Justice





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It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.



replies to the
paradox

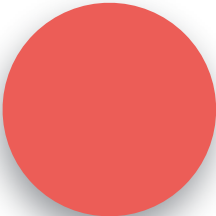








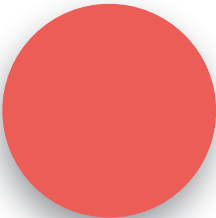






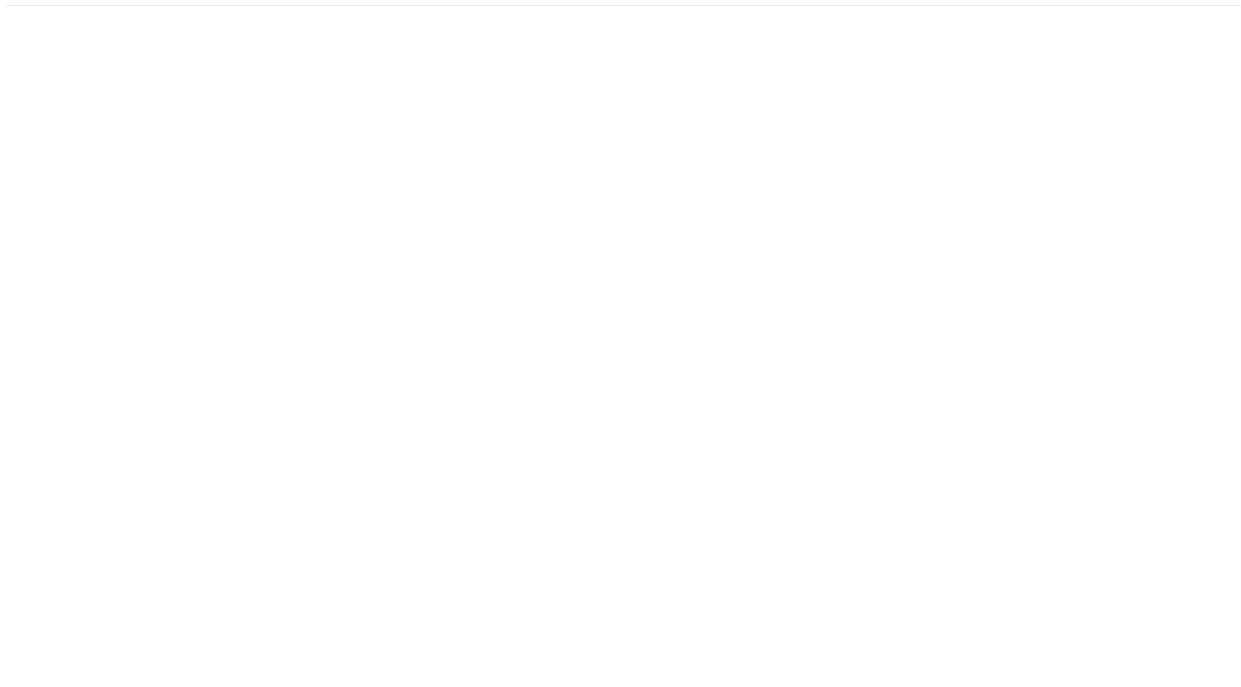
the
paradox of
heaven and
hell





describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:

The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church



another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

eternis in die !!

into external punishment, but the rights into

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a

perfectly good Good?



right hand, but the goat at the left... and

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

this glory, and all the angels with him . . .

but the rights are all in it.

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

they will go away into eternal punishment,

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

and the wild sheep are then from another

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

got to heaven forever, and some to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?





A solid red circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "evil & lives not worth living" is written in a white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

evil & lives
not worth
living